HEALTHY HABITS

Setting practical recovery goals

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

What do you want to work toward?

Recovery goals help you work toward activities that matter to you. You may want to walk a familiar route, understand your medicines, or prepare meals that fit your care plan. Tell your rehabilitation team what you hope to do. Progress includes knowledge and confidence as well as physical strength. [1,3]

Make the goal specific

A broad aim such as being healthier can be hard to act on. Ask the team to help identify one clear next step. For example, your task might be to bring an updated medicine list to the next appointment or follow a particular activity plan they have approved. The goal should say what you will do and when you will review it, without adding an unsafe challenge.

Check that it fits your treatment

A personal goal should support medical advice. Do not set a new lifting target, fluid intake, diet restriction, or exercise pace without checking that it is suitable. Tell the team about pain, balance concerns, fatigue, and other health conditions. If a goal conflicts with discharge instructions, ask for clarification. Choose a step your team has approved. [4]

Choose a change you can repeat

Making one manageable change at a time can help build habits. Look at your schedule, budget, and support before deciding what is realistic. If you want to change a regular meal, ask which adjustment matters most. If a task depends on another person, agree on their role first. A plan that fits your circumstances is easier to review and revise when difficulties arise. [2]

Use a simple record

Keep a short note of the agreed step and whether you were able to follow it. Include questions and barriers rather than treating the record as a scorecard. For activity, use the measures your team recommends. Do not invent a target to meet an unapproved goal. Share the record at review so the team can understand both progress and any reason the plan was difficult.

Plan for an interruption

Illness, transport problems, or a missed appointment can interrupt a routine. Ask what to do if that happens and whom to contact. Do not make up missed exercise by doubling the next session unless the team specifically directs it. If a goal becomes unsuitable, report the problem and revise it. An interruption is information about your circumstances, not a reason to hide from follow-up.

Review the next step together

At review, explain what became easier and what remained difficult. Ask whether to continue, adjust, or replace the goal. Let your health and priorities guide the next step rather than feeling pressure to prove yourself.

References

1. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (n.d.). How cardiac rehabilitation can help heal your heart. https://www.cdc.gov/heart-disease/about/cardiac-rehabilitation-treatment.html

2. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. (n.d.). DASH, living with DASH. https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/health/dash/living-with-dash

3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Cardiac rehabilitation. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000791.htm

4. British Heart Foundation. (n.d.). What is cardiac rehabilitation?. https://www.bhf.org.uk/informationsupport/support/cardiac-rehabilitation/what-is-cardiac-rehab

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Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
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